

MOVE ARCHETYPES

ADEPTS

No wind ever ran as he runs. He's a blur atop the dunes.

- Lady Ghanima Atreides

These archetypes are physical creatures who hate to stay in one place. They like to apply their skills to the real world. They are hard to keep up with, and almost impossible to catch.

ATHLETE

Athletes are those who hone their bodies to achieve great feats of physical prowess. They're often employed as practitioners of sports and games to entertain, but also as teachers and trainers to guide the physical conditioning of a House's members and agents.

- ✧ **Trait:** Athlete
- ✧ **Primary Skill:** Move
- ✧ **Secondary Skill:** Discipline
- ✧ **Focuses:** Grace, Stamina
- ✧ **Talents:** Nimble
- ✧ **Drives:** Athletes are often driven by a sense of pride in their personal accomplishments and a drive for greater Power over their bodies and their lives. Others are driven by Faith in a higher power, in themselves, or in colleagues and teammates.

MESSENGER

Sending messages and packages quickly and securely is a vital part of the business of the Houses, and they rely heavily upon those who can move a communiqué or valuable item reliably to its destination. Trusted couriers are highly prized and can become targets if their cargo is sufficiently valuable. Messengers often learn unusual ways of communicating messages, secret languages, and techniques for sending multiple messages or hiding one message within others, to ensure that only specific people receive certain information.

- ✧ **Trait:** Messenger
- ✧ **Primary Skill:** Move
- ✧ **Secondary Skill:** Communicate
- ✧ **Focuses:** Pilot, Unobtrusive
- ✧ **Talents:** Masterful Innuendo
- ✧ **Drives:** Messengers are entrusted with their employer's secrets, and that gives them influence they can turn into Power. Others, confronted with the dangers of their profession, put their Faith in a higher power to see them through each job.

SCOUT

Working alongside military units and exploratory groups, scouts take on the perilous task of venturing ahead of their comrades to discover what lays ahead. Scouts need to be able to move quickly through unknown and potentially hostile territory undetected, gather information efficiently, and return to tell the tale. This is, understandably, a dangerous and difficult task, and good scouts are valuable.

- ✧ **Trait:** Scout
- ✧ **Primary Skill:** Move
- ✧ **Secondary Skill:** Understand
- ✧ **Focuses:** Endurance, Stealth
- ✧ **Talents:** Putting Theory into Practice
- ✧ **Drives:** The dangerous vocation of a Scout is one undertaken by those driven by Duty, as few would willingly undertake their missions without a good reason. Others see themselves as explorers, seeking to discover new Truths about the universe as they venture into the unknown.

SMUGGLER

Valuable goods often find their ways into hands through unusual or illicit channels, and Smugglers are how that happens. While officially regarded as illegal, these kinds of activities are an integral, invaluable part of the fabric of society... as long as they are kept quiet. Of particular importance are those who smuggle spice from Arrakis, liberating small quantities of the precious substance from the control of whichever House currently controls the planet, and who must contend with deadly sandworms, often-hostile Fremen raiders, and other perils of that harsh world, but who can command a hefty price for their cargo in exchange for their troubles.

- ✧ **Trait:** Smuggler
- ✧ **Primary Skill:** Move
- ✧ **Secondary Skill:** Battle
- ✧ **Focuses:** Pilot, Unobtrusive
- ✧ **Talents:** Subtle Step
- ✧ **Drives:** Smugglers are selfish by nature, as are many who flaunt the law to achieve their goals. Most tend to seek wealth and Power from their work. Others take a stance driven by a sense of Justice, often trying to gain the means to avenge whatever misdeeds forced them into the smuggling life to begin with.

UNDERSTAND ARCHETYPES

ACADEMICS

Belief can be manipulated. Only knowledge is dangerous.

- Scytale, Face Dancer

These archetypes use their wits and powers of observation to understand the world around them. They like to use their minds but often employ their skills outward rather than inward, seeking knowledge as a way to comprehend what surrounds them.

EMPATH

The ability to detect truth and falsehood when others speak is a valuable and powerful one, and one highly sought-after. Only the Reverend Mothers of the Bene Gesserit have mastered full truthsense. But some individuals are simply born with the knack to understand the motives of others. These gifted individuals can always find employ if they are willing to reveal their ability.

- ✧ **Trait:** Empath
- ✧ **Primary Skill:** Understand
- ✧ **Secondary Skill:** Communicate
- ✧ **Focuses:** Body Language, Social Awareness
- ✧ **Talents:** Passive Scrutiny
- ✧ **Drives:** It may seem obvious, but many Empaths have strong opinions on matters of Truth and perception. Others are ambitious, seeing the potential in their ability and the Power they could accrue from using it.

SCHOLAR

Knowledge is power, and a scholar is a seeker and curator of knowledge. Whether working independently or appointed as an expert advisor to a House, scholars collect, study, and archive information—about a single subject, or a range of subjects—to inform and advise others effectively. Scholars may specialize deeply in a single field of study, or they may study a wide range of subjects. Many of the most valuable scholars are also Mentats.

- ✧ **Trait:** Scholar
- ✧ **Primary Skill:** Understand
- ✧ **Secondary Skill:** Discipline
- ✧ **Focuses:** Data Analysis, Deductive Reasoning
- ✧ **Talents:** Intense Study
- ✧ **Drives:** Scholars are frequently driven to pursue their studies because of a deep interest in uncovering the Truth. Others see the value and potential Power to be found within knowledge.

SPY

Espionage is an integral part of the politics between the Houses, the Landsraad, the Spacing Guild, CHOAM, and the other factions in the Imperium, and spies are the ones who perform this work. Some spies involve themselves directly and personally in this work, building elaborate aliases that allow them to move undetected across the Imperium to uncover the secrets their masters need, but this is a dangerous way to do things. Others cultivate networks of informants, gathering information from far and wide... but this has the potential to see misinformation spread if those informants are compromised.

- ✧ **Trait:** Spy
- ✧ **Primary Skill:** Understand
- ✧ **Secondary Skill:** Move
- ✧ **Focuses:** Deductive Reasoning, Kanly
- ✧ **Talents:** Hidden Motives
- ✧ **Drives:** Spies are often driven by a need to know, or control what is seen as, the Truth. Others are instead determined to serve their masters well, driven by a sense of Duty.

STRATEGIST

Warfare, even within the rules of Kanly, is a complex and nuanced affair. Strategists are employed to sift through reams of intelligence on the enemy, and compose the orders of battle, supply chains, deployment of forces, and the overall strategy of war. They are proficient in the science of mass warfare, and the history and traditions of Kanly. Some of the greatest strategists in history have been Mentats, applying their computational thought to the vagaries and variables of war.

- ✧ **Trait:** Strategist
- ✧ **Primary Skill:** Understand
- ✧ **Secondary Skill:** Battle
- ✧ **Focuses:** Kanly, Strategy
- ✧ **Talents:** Master-at-Arms
- ✧ **Drives:** Strategists are experts in the manipulation and coordination of military forces, and thus understand Power extremely well. Many also rely heavily on their Faith in the forces under their command, and in higher powers.

STEP THREE: SKILLS

Each character in *Dune: Adventures in the Imperium* has five skills, as described in the previous chapter: **Battle, Communicate, Discipline, Move, and Understand.** These cover the character's broad aptitudes and capabilities, forming a major part of skill tests the character attempts during play.

All player characters have each skill rated between 4 and 8.

At this stage in character creation, you will have the following skill ratings:

- ❖ The primary skill listed for your archetype is rated at 6
- ❖ The secondary skill listed for your archetype is rated at 5.
- ❖ The other three skills are rated at 4.

Once you've done this, you may increase any skills you wish; you have five points which you may distribute as you see fit between your skills. No skill may be increased above 8 in this way.

Example: Kara's primary skill is *Communicate*, so that starts at 6. Her secondary skill is *Battle*, which therefore starts at 5. Claire decides to put an extra point in each of her other skills to bring them all up to 5, leaving her with 2 left. While she'd like a better *Communicate*, she decides to balance things out with her combat skills and adds the final 2 points to *Battle* and *Move*. This gives her *Battle* 6, *Communicate* 6, *Discipline* 5, *Move* 6, *Understand* 5.

STEP FOUR: FOCUSES

A starting player character has four focuses, representing areas of expertise and specialization beyond their broad skills. These focuses will each be associated with a single skill, which represents the skill which will use that focus most often. But any focus can be used with any skill if it applies appropriately to the action in question. However, a focus of *Gladiatorial Dueling* is going to be used with *Battle* more often than with *Understand*, for example.

Your chosen archetype will provide two focuses, one of which will usually be associated with the archetype's primary skill, and the other of which will usually be associated with the archetype's secondary skill. You should pick a focus for your primary skill and for your secondary skill (even from outside your archetype). But you may also pick either or both offered by your archetype regardless of skill.

Once you've chosen these, you may choose two other focuses, which may be associated with any skills you want.

Example: Claire likes both of the focuses listed for *Commander* (*Inspiration* and *Leadership*), and picks *Inspiration* for her *Communicate* focus. However, she wants something more direct for her *Battle* focus and so instead picks *Short Blades* (representing her training among the House Molay assassins). For her third pick she wants something that will help in House negotiations and takes *Diplomacy* as a *Communicate* focus. For her final pick she decides the Bene Gesserit taught her how to move unseen and takes *Stealth* as a *Move* focus.



STEP FIVE: TALENTS

A starting player character has three talents, representing special abilities, advanced techniques, and other significant benefits. These are abilities which define a character, helping them to stand out and feel special.

Your chosen archetype will provide a single talent, and it will suggest several options which are appropriately thematic for that archetype. You may choose a different talent if you wish, but at least one of your talents should relate to your chosen archetypes in some way.

Some talents, such as Bold, have to be connected to a particular skill. This connection is chosen when the talent is picked and can only apply to that skill. However, such a talent may be chosen again and applied to another skill. So a character might have Bold (Battle) and Bold (Communicate) as two of their talent picks, for example.

Once you've selected that first talent, you may select

DRIVE IMPORTANCE	DRIVE RATING	MEANING
1 st	8	This is the single most important thing for you.
2 nd	7	This is a high priority for you.
3 rd	6	This is certainly something that influences you.
4 th	5	You know that this thing matters, but you have other priorities.
5 th	4	You care very little about this thing.

two other talents. These talents may be selected freely, though individual talents may have certain restrictions on who may take them—Mentat talents can only be taken by Mentats, Bene Gesserit talents may only be taken by Bene Gesserit, and so forth.

The list of talents begins on p.127.

Example: For her first pick, Claire must take Prana-bindu Conditioning as she has Bene Gesserit training. But her other two picks can be anything she likes. As she has access to Bene Gesserit talents, Claire opts for Hyperawareness, as the Sisterhood taught her how to observe. As a mixture of her time with the Sisterhood and her training in the nobility, she takes Masterful Innuendo as her third pick.

STEP SIX: DRIVES & DRIVE STATEMENTS

Until now, the character creation process has focused on "What does the character do?". This step deals with the other side of a character: what do they believe?

Every character has five drives—**Duty, Faith, Justice, Power, and Truth**—which are described in the previous chapter. These are rated between 4 and 8, representing how important that drive is to the character, with 8 representing the most important thing to the character, while 4 represents something the character cares little about.

During this step, you must rank the five drives according to their importance for the character. Then, in order, assign the associated rating:

You can determine this order in any way you want, but the key is that this is the point where you determine who the character is and what they believe. Each archetype includes a couple of suggestions about the drives that might be interesting to play for that archetype, but these are suggestions only, and shouldn't be considered limits on what you create yourself.

Example: After much thought Claire chooses Faith 8, Duty 7, Power 6, Truth 5, and Justice 4. Kara believes that family and House are the bedrock of success, but that ambition is what drives it. While she is not a liar, she feels Truth is too easily manipulated and Justice is rarely found in the Imperium.

Once you've defined the order of your character's drives, you'll need to define some drive statements—a statement for each of the three most important drives. Drive statements are described in more detail on p.105-106, with numerous example statements available there, but this can be a tricky part of character creation, so additional guidance is provided below.

- ⦿ A drive statement is one of the driving forces of the character's worldview and personality, shaping how they interact with the worlds around them and providing motivation for the things they do.
- ⦿ Drive statements should be easy to understand, so that you and the gamemaster can both understand when they're helpful, when they're a hindrance, and when they don't apply at all. If you don't know if a drive statement applies to a situation, you're not able to use it.
- ⦿ You will want to have at least one drive statement that poses a problem for your character, because that's how you can gain more Determination to spend (see p.157).

- ☞ Similarly, you'll want at least one drive statement which is helpful to your character, because that gives you more opportunities to use a higher drive score, and more opportunities to spend Determination.
- ☞ Drive statements do not have to be positive about the drive they're attached to. Someone with a strong drive in Truth doesn't have to be honest, and someone who believes strongly in Faith may believe that faith and religion are dangerous or harmful.
- ☞ Your drive statements can and should change over time. The game allows for a character to challenge their beliefs, changing the order of priority and the attached statements, to reflect how people's feelings and opinions can shift over time. Because they can change, you don't need to worry too much about choosing the perfect statements right away; simple statements might be a better way to start, becoming more complex as you play the character and their feelings grow more nuanced.
- ☞ It doesn't matter if your drive statements contradict one another. A person can hold conflicting beliefs, and the situations when those conflicting beliefs clash is often a source of interesting roleplay and tension in play.
- ☞ A broad range is also good so you have the option to use a statement on any test. With this in mind, you may want to pick one that reflects how you respond physically, one that reflects how you tend to respond mentally, and one that reflects how you respond socially.

Example: Claire needs to pick drive statements for Kara's three highest drives, which are Duty, Faith, and Power. Remembering Kara's faith in her family and House, and her own 'enlightened self interest', she chooses "I am the heir of my House" (for Duty), "My family trusts me" (for Faith), and "I get what I want" (for Power).

ONE WAY TO CHOOSE DRIVES

One possible method for choosing how to order your character's drives is to compare each individual drive against the others, weighing which of two drives is most important to the character.

With five drives in total, this will take ten questions (listed below, for convenience), and whichever drive wins most often is the most important, second most often is second most important, and so forth, until you've gotten your order. If two drives are tied, look at the question asked about those two drives—that'll tell you how to break that tie. If you get three drives all scoring the same amount, you'll need to think about which one your character prioritizes, as there's no easy way to break that tie.

Duty or Faith	Duty or Justice	Duty or Power	Duty or Truth	Faith or Justice
Faith or Power	Faith or Truth	Justice or Power	Justice or Truth	Power or Truth



MAKING ASSETS PERSONAL

If you can usually obtain a knife, or a shield belt if your House is wealthy enough, it may seem pointless to take one as one of your starting assets. The obvious answer may seem to be that you don't. But it isn't quite as simple as that. You may not want to risk being caught out in the few situations where you can't obtain something you rely on.

But, beyond preparedness, if you still want to have a 'ubiquitous item' as an asset, it should probably be more than just a tool or resource—it should be something personal, something special. This may mean that the item takes an unusual form, it's exceptionally effective or well-crafted, or it has some significant (and personal) history behind it. You don't merely own a knife: you own a crysknife, or you proudly bear 'the knife the Duke gave you after the battle of Axian', or you carry a 'poisoned knife'.

Such an item works as a normal knife would, though it might have a higher **Quality** (see p.192), but the item's history may also make it useful in other situations. A crysknife is sacred amongst the Fremmen and bearing one may grant the wielder an advantage in social conflicts with these desert-dwelling warriors. A knife that was a gift might represent a special bond between characters. In these cases, the extra detail given to an asset reveals details about a character's background that can be explored in play.



STEP SEVEN: ASSETS

Assets represent the tools and resources available to a character, which they can use to achieve their goals.

Chapter 7: Assets contains a list of the kinds of assets available.

Each asset is a special kind of trait (see p. 143-144), which describes a tool, resource, or something else useful which a character possesses. These assets are used during a conflict (as described in **Chapter 6: Conflict**) to overcome opponents and obstacles. Some of these assets are **tangible**—representing physical things, from weapons and other small possessions, to vehicles such as groundcars and ornithopters, to squads of troops and the services of agents and other subordinates. Others are **intangible**, representing contacts, favors, the ability to call upon friends, and similar useful things which have no physical presence in their own right.

A starting character should have three assets, one of which must be tangible.

SIZE AND SCALE

When it comes to tangible assets, most examples a character will have should be personal equipment... but the possibility exists for assets which represent things larger than a character's personal effects.

As a rule of thumb, your personal assets can include anything you could carry on your person, any vehicle which you could operate yourself, or any group of subordinates which you could lead and coordinate alone, such as a squad of troops. Larger vehicles—ones requiring a crew to operate—and larger groups of subordinates that require other officers or a deeper chain of command are not suitable as assets for a single character, though circumstances might grant you command of these larger-scale assets in certain circumstances.

Example: As Kara is a fighter, Claire decides one of Kara's assets is a knife given to her by the master assassin who taught her. As knives are easily obtained, she decides it has the special attribute of being easy to conceal. As a noblewoman she also has a personal ornithopter as her second asset. While it obviously can't be carried with her, it is easily accessible. Claire was tempted to create a handmaiden for Kara, but another player luckily wants to play such a character already (who will be called Anna). So instead she opts for something intangible and decides she has some blackmail material on a past lover. Who that is, and what it involves, can be decided later.

STEP EIGHT: FINISHING TOUCHES

At this stage, your character is almost complete, and needs only a few final elements and adjustments. This serves as a last chance to customize your character before you begin playing, and a chance to make a few decisions to turn the character from a collection of numbers and rules into a distinct person.

TRAIT

Select one additional trait for your character, reflecting the character's reputation and how they are regarded by others. These do not necessarily have to be accurate descriptions of who the character is, only how others perceive them; a character may seek to cultivate a reputation distinct from who they actually are.

Example: *Claire decides that Kara's dedication to power needs to be tempered a little and decides that Honorable should be her reputation trait.*

AMBITION

Each player character has an ambition, which guides their long-term actions. A character who takes steps to achieve their ambitions will become more capable, more influential, and generally more effective.

During character creation, your character's ambition should be based on their highest-rated drive, and your gamemaster will work with you to define one for your character, helping to create something which can come up in play frequently. This ambition may change over time as a character's drives shift.

- ☞ **Duty** ambitions are about service to a cause or group, discovering or understanding one's place in the universe, or freedom from the strictures and responsibilities that constrain you.
- ☞ **Faith** ambitions are zealous crusades, spiritual fulfillment, matters of prophecy or destiny, or attempts to undermine or destroy those things.
- ☞ **Justice** ambitions are driven by a sense of fairness or balance, or a desire to right wrongs and injustices... including personal grudges and vendettas.
- ☞ **Power** ambitions are about gaining influence or status, taking those things from others, manipulating those with influence or status, or changing the ways that people gain influence or status.
- ☞ **Truth** ambitions often include uncovering knowledge or revealing secrets, concealing knowledge or protecting secrets, spreading knowledge (including propaganda or misinformation), or exposing the lies of others.

Example: *Kara's highest drive is Faith, and so Claire decides she believes in destiny. Kara wants to gain power for her House but also wishes to become a premier assassin. Her dream is to appear to be an ordinary noblewoman but create a reputation as a master assassin that no one knows the real identity of.*

PERSONAL DETAILS

Coming up with the details that turn a character from a collection of numbers and rules into a person is a vital part of character creation, but a part that obviously should be left to the very end, bringing together those disparate elements into a cohesive whole.

NAME

Every character needs a name. This can be anything, though it's probably best to avoid anything that would break the mood of the game. A character's name reflects their culture—different worlds may have differing traditions for how people are named—and their upbringing. Characters who belong to the group's House (rather than being vassals or servants) will likely use the House's name as their surname, in part or in full. Characters may also have private or personal names, used only by those close to them, or they may assume official or ceremonial names for specific purposes. Many characters may also be known more by informal nicknames rather than their full name. Characters who engage in criminal activity or espionage may have multiple names and aliases which they use instead of their normal name.

Many cultures use a patronymic or matronymic—the father's or mother's name, with a prefix or suffix such as '-son'—alongside or instead of a family name, or they may keep the family names of both parents. It's also fairly common for some cultures to place the family name first, with the personal name afterwards.

Many names found in the novels are provided as an example below, providing common masculine and feminine names, as well as a sample of family names. Given the mixture of cultures, almost any name can suit a Dune character.

- ☞ **Male:** Abulurd, Arkie, Aureluis, Bijaz, Cammar, Dmitri, D'murr, Dominic, Duncan, Edric, Elrood, Farad'n, Feyd, Glossu, Gurney, Hasimir, Iakin, Jamis, Korba, Leto, Mattai, Miles, Moneo, Otheym, Pardot, Paul, Piter, Rhombur, Shaddam, Stilgar, Thufir, Tyros, Victor, Vorian, Wellington, Xavier
- ☞ **Female:** Alia, Anirul, Chani, Dhuri, Faroula, Ghanima, Helen, Helena, Irulan, Jessica, Kaliea, Margot, Murbella, Norma, Siona, Wensicia

☞ Surnames (usually by House for nobility, but also):

Bludd, Calimar, Cour, Dinari, Garon, Hawat, Idaho, Noree, Noret, Pilru, Reed, Reffa, Rund, Trig, Tuek, Wu

PERSONALITY

Once you've got an idea of what your character does, and believes, and you've thought about how others perceive them, consider what sort of personality your character has. Are they stoic or grim? Are they disciplined and orderly? Adventurous? Wise? Thoughtful? Tired of routine? Calm and circumspect? Even a few adjectives like this can help in locking down the personality of a character.

Whatever you decide, your character isn't always like this—like any person, your character is a nuanced, complex individual who is affected by moods and circumstances as much as their drives and personality. Characters can, and will, evolve over time, but it's a good idea to understand how your character is likely to behave in normal circumstances.

A character's drives and drive statements are a good basis for this: a character who is devout or dutiful may act in ways that reflect their beliefs. If you've had any difficulty coming up with drive statements for a character, now is a good time to think about them in more detail.

If you are stuck, try and find answers to the following questions:

- ☞ Are you more of an introvert or extrovert?
- ☞ What is the first thing anyone notices about you?
- ☞ What part of yourself do you rarely show to others?
- ☞ What does it take for you to trust someone?
- ☞ What makes you angry?
- ☞ When was the last time you cried?

APPEARANCE

What does your character look like? A character's environment and upbringing will shape this to some degree—such as the distinctive blue-in-blue eyes of those who have lived on Arrakis for years—but the finer points such as build, height, ethnicity, or any distinguishing features will give the other players and the gamemaster something to picture when thinking of their characters. Are they distinctive or average-looking? Do they have any habits, or behavioral quirks? It's often useful to give characters some sort of visual description.

It may even be useful to think of an actor who you can imagine portraying your character: the appearance, voice, and mannerisms of an actor can serve as a source of inspiration.

If you are stuck, try and find answers to the following questions:

- ☞ Do you usually wear some sort of uniform?
- ☞ Do you take care of your appearance? If so, how much?

- ☞ Do you like to be noticed or dress to hide away?
- ☞ Do you like to stay fashionable or do you keep to your own style?
- ☞ Are your outfits practical or impractical?
- ☞ Have you any distinguishing marks, such as a tattoo or a scar?

RELATIONSHIPS

Life does not occur in isolation. Characters are connected to others and will have formed relationships throughout their life. Consider your character's family relationships: Where is the rest of their family? Do they have a spouse or partner somewhere? Is the character in contact with the rest of their family regularly, and are they close at hand, or on a distant world somewhere else in the Imperium?

What about the people around the character? How do the main characters get on with one another? How does the character regard other members, agents, and servants of the House, and how are they regarded in turn? Is the character close friends with other characters in the House's service, relaxing with them? Does the character have any personal enemies or rivals?

These details can make the interaction between characters more interesting and add more depth to your character. Like a character's personality, a character's relationships can—and should—evolve over time, and some relationships may become so strong (whether friendly or adversarial) that they become major factors in the character's life.

If you are stuck, try and find answers to the following questions:

- ☞ Do you have a family and how often do you see them?
- ☞ Who among the other player characters do you like best?
- ☞ Who among the other player characters do you like the least?
- ☞ Do you believe in the goals of your House or is it just a job to you?
- ☞ How much do you respect the rulers of your House?
- ☞ What (if anything) would make you betray those around you?

Example: Kara Molay is an average looking woman in her early twenties. She has a natural grace developed from her exceptional fighting skills. She doesn't often say very much, preferring to watch those around her first. She dresses well in the fashions of court, but doesn't try to stand out. She is utterly dedicated to her family but also considers anything that benefits her to benefit the House. While she is dedicated to her friends, she would sacrifice almost anything to advance her House.

KARA MOLAY

COMMANDER

DRIVE

STATEMENT

DUTY: **7** I am the heir of my House.

FAITH: **8** My family trusts me.

JUSTICE: **4**

POWER: **6** I get what I want.

TRUTH: **5**

As the eldest daughter of House Molay, Kara was sent to the Bene Gesserit for training, as much for her edification as to keep her out of the way. However, instead of returning from the Sisters with courtly graces, she came back to House Molay a deadly knife fighter and skilled politician. She now works to reclaim her rightful place as heir to the House against her many devious brothers, as she sees all of them as unfit to rule.

SKILL

FOCUSES

BATTLE: **6** Short Blades

COMMUNICATE: **6** Diplomacy, Inspiration

DISCIPLINE: **5**

MOVE: **6** Stealth

UNDERSTAND: **5**

Traits: Noble, Honorable, Bene Gesserit

Ambition: To become a secret master assassin (Faith)

TALENTS

- ✧ Hyperawareness
- ✧ Masterful Innuendo
- ✧ Prana-bindu Conditioning

STARTING ASSETS

- ✧ Blackmail Evidence
- ✧ Concealable Knife
- ✧ Personal Ornithopter



TALENTS



A character is more than the sum of their parts, and a character's skills, drives, and focuses alone do not give a full picture of what they are truly capable of. Exceptional abilities, such as Mentat training, or the many and varied powers of a Bene Gesserit, are a form of talent, but talents can take other forms too, representing some of the ways which set a player character apart from ordinary people.

Talents normally take the form of a mechanical bonus—re-rolls, bonus Momentum, the ability to succeed automatically on certain tests, or unique ways to use Momentum, Threat, or Determination. No talent may be selected more than once, unless otherwise noted.

The following is a selection of talents which characters may select.

ADRENALINE SHOT (SUK DOCTOR TALENT)

You are adept at getting people back on their feet, even if you only make them forget their pain for a moment.

By using an action, the character can remove the effects of any physical complication from a character who is in the same zone. This complication is not removed and returns at the end of the scene unless otherwise removed. This talent can only be used once on a given character during each scene, but can be used on each character.

ADVISOR (SKILL)

You've got a knack for guiding others through problems.

When you choose this talent, select a single skill. Whenever you assist an ally and you use that skill, the ally you assist may re-roll a single d20 in their dice pool.

BINDING PROMISE

Whether through your demeanor, your reputation, or the method of your persuasion, you have a way of making people reluctant to break faith with you.

When you succeed at a Communicate test to persuade someone to agree to a promise or agreement, you may spend one, two, or three points of Momentum to make that agreement binding. If that person wishes to break the promise, they must spend Threat equal to twice the Momentum you spent.

BOLD (SKILL)

When you take calculated risks, you tend to succeed more often than seems reasonable.

When you select this talent, choose a single skill. When you attempt a test using the chosen skill, and you buy additional d20s by generating Threat for the gamemaster, you may re-roll a single d20 in that dice pool.

BOLSTER

Your certainty and resolve are a beacon to others, who might waver without your example.

Once per scene, when an ally fails a skill test, you may immediately spend 2 points of Momentum or add 2 to Threat to allow that ally to re-roll their dice pool. When they re-roll, they may use your Discipline score instead of the skill they were using.

CALCULATED PREDICTION (MENTAT TALENT)

Using the facts and figures you have memorized and your ability to process information, you can attempt to predict the future. No such predictions are 100% perfect, as there may be variables you are unaware of that affect the future.

You may spend a few minutes to meditate upon predicting the future. This requires an Understand test with a Difficulty of 4; if successful, you may ask the Gamemas-

ter to state something that is likely to occur in the future. You may ask for one additional prediction for every two points of Momentum you spend. The Gamemaster can make these predictions vague and they do not have to explain any context for the prediction or why that thing is likely to occur.

CAUTIOUS (SKILL)

You are patient and circumspect, acting only when the odds are in your favor.

When you select this talent, choose a single skill. When you attempt a test using that skill, and you buy additional d20s by spending Momentum, you may re-roll a single d20 in that dice pool.

COLLABORATION (SKILL)

You've coached your allies to capitalize on your expertise, and that effort has paid off.

When you select this talent, choose a single skill with a rating of 6 or more. Whenever an ally attempts a test using that skill, and you can communicate with them, you may spend 2 points of Momentum to allow them to use your score for that skill, and one of your focuses (if applicable).

COMBAT MEDIC (SUK DOCTOR TALENT)

You are skilled at offering rapid medical attention, even during a battle.

When an ally in combat has suffered points towards the requirement to defeat them, you may spend 1 point of Momentum to reduce that point total by 2 as an action.

CONSTANTLY WATCHING

You're vigilant, bordering on paranoid... and little catches you off-guard.

Whenever you attempt a skill test to detect danger or hidden enemies, you reduce the Difficulty by 2, to a minimum of 0. In addition, once per scene, when an enemy chooses to Keep the Initiative, you can increase the cost to do so by +2.

COOL UNDER PRESSURE (SKILL)

When the situation gets tough, you take a deep breath and get the job done.

When you select this talent, choose a single skill. When you attempt a test using that skill, before rolling you may spend a Determination point to automatically succeed at that test, but you generate no Momentum. The normal conditions for spending Determination still apply.

DECISIVE ACTION

You take risks in combat, often ones that seem foolhardy or needless. You have a knack for making those gambles pay off.

In a conflict, when you succeed at a Battle test to remove an opponent's assets, and you bought one or more dice by generating Threat, you may spend 2 points of Momentum to remove a second enemy asset.

DEDICATION

Your commitment to a cause is unwavering, and this has carried you through many a tough situation.

At the start of a scene, if there is no Momentum in the group pool, roll 1d20. If you roll equal to or less than your Discipline score, add 1 to the group Momentum pool.

DELIBERATE MOTION

Every step you take is considered, and you are exceptionally sure-footed.

When you attempt a Move test and suffer one or more complications, you may spend Momentum to ignore some or all of those complications; this costs 1 point of Momentum per complication ignored.

DIRECT

Your will and presence can drive others to act swiftly and efficiently.

Once per scene, you may command an ally or subordinate to act. This requires no test from you, but the commanded ally may immediately attempt an action of their own, and you may assist any test they attempt. If done during a conflict, the ally acts on your turn regardless of if they have already acted, and this does not prevent them acting later during the round.

DRIVEN

Your determination does not waver.

After you spend a point of Determination, roll 1d20. If you roll equal to or under your Discipline rating (by itself), you immediately regain that point of Determination.

DUAL FEALTY

You owe your service and your life to two different factions equally, and you have the trust of both.

Choose two factions to be loyal to. This will normally be your House and another group such as the Bene Gesserit, but it can be to any two factions you would reasonably have contact with. Both factions are aware of your loyalties to both and expect that you will not betray one to the other. You may interact on friendly terms with members of both factions, without any expectations of betrayal or other peril.

FAILED NAVIGATOR (SPACING GUILD TALENT)

You underwent trials to become a Guild Navigator, but you failed to meet the standards required... yet, for one brief moment, your consciousness became one with the universe. In times of stress, your mind sometimes repeats this, granting you a momentary insight of some kind.

Whenever you spend a point of Determination, the gamemaster will grant you an additional insight. This may relate to your current activities, or it may be completely unrelated.

FIND TROUBLE

You know where to find the criminal element wherever you go.

Wherever you are, once per adventure, you can always contact the criminal underworld or black market (as long as there is one in that area). This doesn't mean they will be well disposed toward you, just that you can find a contact.

GUILDSMAN (SPACING GUILD TALENT)

You have connections to the Spacing Guild, granting you more access to their resources than most. You are not a Navigator, but you may be an agent, representative, banker, diplomat, or similar associate of the Guild.

Once per adventure, you may call upon your Spacing Guild connection to use Guild facilities or resources, or to organize a meeting with important persons within the Guild. You do not have the authority to make demands of the Guild itself. If you need to use Guild resources more than once during the course of an adventure, the second time adds 2 to Threat, the third time adds 4, and so forth, adding +2 to the cost each time, as your increased use risks drawing undue attention to you.

HIDDEN MOTIVES

You are a master at concealing your intentions and motivations. Few truly know what drives you, even if they think they understand you.

When an opponent fails an Understand or Communicate test against you, you may immediately create a trait which reflects a mistaken belief they have about you.

HYPERAWARENESS (BENE GESSERIT TALENT)

Your training has honed your awareness to an incredible degree, allowing you to notice details too small for others to perceive. Armed with these insights, you can uncover secrets and truths that others may be oblivious to.

Whenever you spend Momentum to Obtain Information about the current situation, your current location, or a person you can currently observe, you may ask two questions for the first point of Momentum spent. Further, the limits of what others would be able to notice do not apply to you for any questions.

IMPERIAL CONDITIONING (SUK DOCTOR TALENT)

Through intense psychological conditioning, you cannot take a human life, or cause a human to come to harm. This is a necessary step, for those with power and status must be free of the fear that their physicians might be assassins.

You cannot willingly inflict harm upon or kill a human being. Any attempt to coerce you into such an action automatically fails, and you automatically succeed on any skill test to persuade another that you intend them no harm.

IMPROVED RESOURCES

You are entrusted with greater access to the tools and resources you need to achieve your goals.

You may increase the number of assets you possess by +1. This talent may be purchased multiple times.

IMPROVISED WEAPON

You are able to turn the most innocuous items into deadly weapons at a moment's notice.

Once per scene you may create a Quality 0 asset (at no cost) that you can use in a personal or skirmish conflict. It might be a rock, broken bottle, or shard of glass, but it is enough to function as a weapon. The asset is removed at the end of any conflict it is used for, as it will be too badly damaged to use again.

INTENSE STUDY

You are extremely well-read, with vast amounts of knowledge about a wide range of subjects.

Once per scene, you may use your Understand skill on a single skill test instead of any other skill, and you are counted as having a focus for that test.

MAKE HASTE

There is value in speed, even if there are consequences.

When you attempt a Move test, you may choose to suffer one additional complication in exchange for scoring one automatic success on the test. During any conflict, you may add 1 to Threat to take the first action, regardless of who would otherwise act first.

MASK OF POWER

You can intimate that you know more than you do about an enemy's secrets.

Once per scene you may create an asset (at no cost) such as blackmail evidence or an owed favor that will allow you to initiate an intrigue or espionage conflict with a person of your choosing. The asset is a lie, of course; you don't have anything, but your target doesn't know that. The asset is removed once the conflict is over, and if you are defeated the fact you were bluffing is exposed and you suffer an additional complication.

MASTER-AT-ARMS

Your expertise in battle is considerable, and few can match your effectiveness in combat.

At the start of a duel, skirmish, or battle scene, select a single asset that represents a melee weapon or a unit of troops. Due to your prowess, you may spend 1 Momen-

tum to improve that asset's Quality by 1 for the next conflict in this scene.

MASTERFUL INNUENDO

You have a special knack for saying more than one thing at once, conveying one message with the literal meaning of your words and another with innuendo, allusions, and signals that only the intended recipients will understand.

When you attempt a Communicate test, you may choose to increase the Difficulty of the test by +1 to conceal a hidden message within your words. You must state who is the intended recipient of this hidden message. People other than the intended recipient cannot discern that you have concealed another message, unless they have this talent, or some other ability to detect things which people cannot normally detect (such as the Hyperawareness talent).

MENTAT DISCIPLINE (MENTAT TALENT)

Intense mental conditioning and extensive training have developed your intellect into a potent and valuable thing. You can retain and process vast amounts of information at extraordinary speeds.

You have almost perfect recall, for even the most complex data. When making an Understand test that applies to recalling data, one of the D20s in your pool may be considered to have rolled a 1 instead of rolling it.

MIND PALACE (MENTAT TALENT)

You have exceptional recall and can reconstruct events and places you have experienced with perfect accuracy, allowing you to revisit them later.

You may attempt a Difficulty 0 Understand test to recall a past event or a place you have previously been to. Momentum you generate on this test may be spent to recall facts and details about that event or location; this is treated like *Obtain Information*, but you may ask questions about things you have previously encountered, rather than merely those which are currently present in the scene.

NIMBLE

You're quick on your feet, and few obstacles can impede you.

When attempting a Move test to move over, around, or through difficult terrain or similar physical obstacles (such as during a duel or skirmish), you may reduce the Difficulty of the test by 2. If this reduces the Difficulty to 0, you may move over or around that obstacle freely as if it wasn't there.

OTHER MEMORY (BENE GESSERIT TALENT)

You have undergone the Agony attended by another Reverent Mother, and now you can draw upon the memories and wisdom of all your ancestors. In doing so, you have become a Reverent Mother of the Bene Gesserit.

You must be a Reverend Mother of the Bene Gesserit (and have an appropriate trait reflecting this) to select this talent. If this talent is selected in play, another Reverend Mother must be on hand and in physical contact to pass this genetic memory on to you.

Whenever you attempt a test where knowledge of past events—even those which may have occurred many generations ago—would be beneficial, you score three automatic successes. You may also share your genetic memory with other Reverend Mothers at will.

PASSIVE SCRUTINY

You are quick to notice details which may be of importance later.

When you enter a scene, you may ask one question of the gamemaster as if you'd spent Momentum to *Obtain Information*.

PERFORMER

Your skill with music or poetry helps to soothe and inspire your comrades.

Once per scene you may entertain the group with a short performance. This might be playing the balliset, singing, reciting a poem, dancing, or even juggling. Once the performance is over you may add 1 to the group's Momentum pool.

PRANA-BINDU CONDITIONING (BENE GESSERIT TALENT)

You have absolute control over your body. Every muscle and every nerve is under your control, and you have even mastered your own body chemistry and metabolism.

Whenever you attempt a Move or Discipline test which relies on your control of your body, you may re-roll a single d20. You can perfectly control your breathing, heart rate, and your internal organs (including the ability to choose whether to conceive a child, and to determine the child's physical and genetic traits).

PRIORITY BOARDING (SPACING GUILD TALENT)

You can call in a few favors to ensure the Guild inspectors don't take too long looking at your luggage.

You don't need to offer bribes to ensure Guild inspectors simply take your word for it that all your cargo and possessions are as they should be. This allows you to smuggle anything aboard a Guild ship. However, if something you have brought aboard creates problems for the Guild, you will lose this talent.

PUTTING THEORY INTO PRACTICE

You've learned how to quickly turn newfound knowledge into a practical advantage.

Once per scene, when you *Obtain Information*, you may create a trait for free, which must represent an

advantage, opportunity, or weakness you've identified with the information you received.

RANSACK

When time is of the essence, you prioritize getting the work done over covering your tracks.

When you attempt an Understand test to search an area, you may add 2 to Threat to reduce the difficulty of the test by 1, and to halve the amount of time the test takes to attempt.

RAPID MANEUVER

You're fast, able to cross ground, find the shortest route, and bring your tools to bear quicker than most.

When attempting a skill test to reach a destination quickly when moving on foot or in a vehicle, reduce the Difficulty by 1. In a conflict, when moving an asset, you may move the asset an additional zone for 1 point of Momentum, rather than 2.

RAPID RECOVERY

You return to fighting form quickly after being injured, even when it may be risky to return to the fray.

Once per scene, at the start of your turn, you may add +2 to Threat to remove a complication which represents an injury. In addition, you may pay to Resist Defeat one additional time during a conflict.

RESILIENCE (SKILL) (FREMEN TALENT)

It takes a lot to put you down in a conflict. You get back up more often than most.

Usually you may only 'Resist Defeat' once per scene. You can do so twice per scene, but only when in a conflict using the listed skill.

RIGOROUS CONTROL

You are an island of calm amidst the chaos of the universe, maintaining control over yourself when you cannot control anything else.

Whenever you are attempting an extended task where the requirement is based on one of your skills, at the cost of 1 Momentum you may use your Discipline for that requirement instead of the skill normally used. If the requirement would normally be based on your Discipline, reduce the requirement by 1 for that extended task.

SPECIALIST

Your duties require you to manage a greater type of a specific kind of asset.

You may purchase this talent multiple times. Each time you select this talent, choose a single category of asset from the following list: dueling, warfare, espionage, or intrigue. You increase the number of assets you possess by +2, but those two additional assets must be from the chosen category.

STIRRING RHETORIC

You are an able public speaker, and your words carry weight and purpose.

When you succeed at a Communicate test to address a group of people, you may select a number of those people equal to your Communicate skill. Those characters may re-roll a single d20 on the next test they attempt which uses the same drive that you used on your Communicate test.

SUBTLE STEP

You're well-versed in methods of avoiding notice, and you reveal little that you do not intend to.

When you attempt a Move test to sneak or otherwise pass unseen through an area, or when you attempt to move an asset subtly during a conflict, the first extra d20 you purchase for the test is free.

SUBTLE WORDS

You are skilled at swaying others with a few quiet words spoken in the right place at the right time. Even they may not realize what influence your words have had.

When you attempt a Communicate test, and you buy one or more dice by spending Momentum, you may create a new trait for free upon the character you have spoken to, which reflects your influence upon their thoughts or mood.

THE REASON I FIGHT (DRIVE)

Skill is not the only factor in determining victory; those who want it more, and those who are driven by a greater sense of purpose, may triumph when they should have failed.

When you select this talent, choose a single drive rated 6 or higher. When you attempt a Battle test using the chosen drive, and the drive's statement aligns with the action being attempted, you may re-roll 1d20.

THE SLOW BLADE

The slow blade pierces the shield. You're well-versed in the subtle ways of avoiding an opponent's defenses.

When you make an attack during a duel or a skirmish using a melee weapon, and you buy one or more dice by spending Momentum, you may choose one of the enemy's assets in the same zone as your attack; you can ignore that asset during your attack.

TO FIGHT SOMEONE IS TO KNOW THEM (SKILL)

You are an expert in studying your foes in conflict, learning how they think and gleaning secrets from them based on how they move, attack, and defend.

When you select this talent, choose a skill. When you win a conflict using the chosen skill, you gain two bonus

Momentum points, which you may use to *Obtain Information* or to create a trait that represents some knowledge or insight you've gained about your opponent.

TWISTED MENTAT (MENTAT TALENT)

Your Mentat abilities were shaped and engineered by the Bene Tleilax to leave you unencumbered by such petty things as morality, taboo, or decency.

Whenever you attempt an Understand test, you generate one bonus Momentum point for each die you bought by adding to Threat. This bonus Momentum may only be used to *Obtain Information* about the most effective ways to harm or inflict pain upon a person within the scene, or to create a trait which represents a weakness you have discovered which you can exploit. This Talent may only be chosen in character creation.

UNQUESTIONABLE LOYALTY

Your loyalty to your House is such that it can drive you to action even in the direst of circumstances.

At the start of each adventure, you begin with one additional point of Determination. This extra point can only be used on an action which is in direct service to your House.

VERIFY (MENTAT TALENT)

You have so much data at your fingertips you can see where it contradicts and determine where falsehoods lie.

You may spend a point of Momentum to ask the gamemaster if a piece of information you have is true or false. You need not be making a skill test as with *Obtain Information*, and the data can be your supposition as much as a specific document or rumor.

VOICE (BENE GESSERIT TALENT)

You have been trained to modulate your voice to influence the subconscious minds of others. With this skill you can subtly manipulate others, alter motivations and moods, or even compel action from the unwilling.

You may use Voice whenever you speak to someone else, though you must be able to observe them for a short while beforehand, and they must be able to hear you speak. When you use Voice, you may add one, two, or three points to Threat to score the same number of automatic successes on any Communicate test made to influence your chosen target. The greater the number of automatic successes, the more overt your use of Voice, which others may notice. Your training also allows you to buy those automatic successes on any test made to resist the effects of Voice.



CREATION IN PLAY



The other method of creating a main character is somewhat simpler, but does require that you have a greater understanding of who you want your character to be and what you want them to do before you begin playing *Dune: Adventures in the Imperium*.

This method allows you to partially create your character, leaving a number of details undefined, so that you can choose them when they come up during play, revealing the character through their actions in the same way that a character's capabilities might be revealed to a reader or viewer in a story.

Creating the partial character should be a relatively quick process, but one that requires you to make a few decisions early. This method uses the following steps:

1. Create your character's concept (and faction template if appropriate).
2. Choose an archetype and record primary (7) and secondary (6) skill ratings.
3. Choose a focus.
4. Choose one talent.
5. Choose one drive and create a drive statement.
6. Choose one asset.
7. Fill in character details.
8. Begin play!

STEP ONE: CONCEPT

Create concept and pick faction if appropriate.

Just as in planned character creation, the first step in creating a player character is to decide what general sort of character to create. Again, it's helpful to keep this concept relatively vague at this stage, as it gives you room to change and adapt.

If you decide you want to play a faction character, choose one of the templates and note the additional trait.

Once you have a concept that you're happy with, move on to the next step.

STEP TWO: ARCHETYPE

From archetype, record one trait, primary skill (7), and secondary skill (6).

Next, select a general archetype for the character and record the career trait that comes with it. Put a rating of 7 for the primary skill listed and a rating of 6 for the secondary skill listed. Ignore the other three skills for now. It is perfectly reasonable to pick an archetype based only on the primary and secondary skills it offers and amend it to suit your concept.

These archetypes are the same as those listed under planned character creation, starting on p.114.

STEP THREE: FOCUSES

Pick two focuses.

Your chosen archetype will provide two focuses, one of which will usually be associated with the archetype's primary skill, and the other of which will be associated with the archetype's secondary skill. Record these as your first two focuses. However, if there is a focus you feel would suit your character better you may substitute it for either of these.

Your character has two other focuses, but these are left blank for the moment: you'll decide what they are during play.

STEP FOUR: TALENTS

Pick one talent.

Pick one of the talents listed in your archetype as your first talent. If you have opted for a faction template, you must pick one of your mandatory talents for this option. If your faction demands multiple mandatory talents, record them all now (and you will have fewer to choose during play).

Your character will have two other talents, but these are left blank for the moment: you'll decide what they are during play.

STEP FIVE:

DRIVES AND DRIVE STATEMENTS

Pick one drive (8) and its statement.

Every character has five drives—**Duty**, **Faith**, **Justice**, **Power**, and **Truth**—which are described on p.105. From these five, select one drive. This is the character's most important drive and receives a rating of 8. This is the thing most important to the character, so you need to know it in advance.

Next, define a drive statement for this drive. Drive statements are described in detail on p.106, and additional guidance on creating them appears in the **Planned Creation** section on p.120-121.

The other four drives remain blank at this stage: you'll fill them in later, during play.

STEP SIX: ASSETS

Pick one asset.

A starting character should have three assets, one of which must be tangible, but during character creation you only need to choose one of them right away. This will presumably be the asset the character possesses which is most important or obvious.

The other two assets will be decided later, during play.

STEP SEVEN: CHARACTER DETAILS

At this stage, your character is almost ready for play, but you need to make a few decisions to turn the character from a collection of numbers and rules into a distinct person.

Elements like the character's name—so that other characters know what to call them—and a basic sense of their appearance, personality, and so forth are crucial for bringing the character to life, even in this partially-assembled sense.

Guidance on character details of this sort can be found on p.123.

STEP EIGHT: BEGIN PLAY!

Your character will have numerous blank spaces on their character sheet:

- You'll have one **trait** left to define, which will reflect your character's reputation.
- You'll have three **skills** left to define.
- You'll have two **focuses** left to define.
- You'll have two **talents** left to define.
- You'll have four **drives** left to define, along with drive statements for two of them.
- You'll have to define your character's **ambition**.
- You'll have two additional **assets** left to define.

While you have these details undefined, you may not gain advancement points or purchase advancements for your character.

RUNNING CREATION IN PLAY

While you have a character ready to go, it isn't quite complete. However, as you play the game and develop the concept you have of the character, you can gradually fill in the rest of their skills and abilities. Whenever your character is faced with a new situation, they might use an ability they already have, or choose to define one that would be useful from their remaining options. By defining an ability in this way, the character is not suddenly learning how to perform it; instead, they finally reveal an ability they already had to the other characters.

So, if your character does not have a rating for their Battle skill, they might choose to define it in their first combat. As such, it is up to the player to decide how good they are, based on what options they still must define. You might decide the character is a lethal fighter or not suited for fighting at all. But whatever the rating is, it is something they have always had. This means that if you don't have a rating in the Battle skill and your character gets into a fight, you will either have to run, hide, or make a decision about how good they are pretty quickly. It also means that if the character has boasted of their martial prowess before defining it and the player decides to give them a low Battle score when it is first tested, they have been clearly exaggerating their ability.

As a player it is tempting to assign the highest rating available to the skill you need each time you are faced with a situation. But it is important to remember that eventually you will only have your worst skills left. So consider carefully what you want your character to be good at in the long term and be prepared to take the odd knock or two as you learn about their true abilities. It is also worth watching what each of the other players pick and allowing each other the spotlight. If you are faced with defining your Communicate skill and another player seems keen to have a high Communicate rating, it is worth taking a step back and letting them shine in the situation. As everyone has the same values to assign, sooner or later everyone will get a moment to be the best at something, and this will make the group more dynamic. Remember, your characters are a team, so it is fine to rely on each other. Don't expect to be good at everything.

When running creation in play, the gamemaster should bear a few things in mind as well. The main thing to remember is that the players will need opportunities to define their characters' attributes and abilities. It is therefore a good idea to run as many situations as required to test each of their abilities. While this is reasonably simple for skills, it is a lot harder for drives, as a player may often use the same drive for many different

tests and situations. Focuses and talents also offer a problem as the player won't know them all. If the gamemaster is familiar with the various special abilities, they should suggest them to the players when they might be useful. "You know, if you had the Bold (Communicate) talent this test would be a lot easier." Failing that, the players can flag moments they would like to be just that little bit better than usual in a situation and use those moments to check in the book for a talent or focus that they can define to help them out.

While the gamemaster can run creation in play with any adventure, they might consider running more of an 'origin story' for the group. The adventure might bring the characters together, possibly for their first mission. But it might even focus on how they came to be part of their House and what made them pledge loyalty to it.

The needs of continued character creation will slow down the action a little. But that's fine as you are all getting use to the rules and what would suit the characters. So, take your time and allow the group to discuss what they feel would be a useful ability to add to the group (even if the players themselves don't want it for their character). While there is a lot of fun to be had creating in play, the group should also be focused on completing the characters. For this reason, the gamemaster should set a limit to how long this part of the campaign will go on. They might want every character done by the end of the first session or allow three or four sessions or a full starting adventure to be completed before calling creation to an end. Whatever the limit, anything undefined by the end of this time should be defined outside of play at the end of the session. By this time all the players should be familiar enough with their characters and the rules to make informed decisions and complete their characters.

To make creation in play simpler we have divided the remaining character choices into a series of options that can be used a limited amount of times. Each player should ideally copy this list and tick them off as they use them.

DEFINING A TRAIT

During play, whenever you attempt an action which may be affected by how others regard your character, you may choose to define your remaining trait before the action is resolved. When the action is resolved, the newly-defined trait is considered in how the action is resolved.

This option may be used **once**.

DEFINING SKILLS

During play, when you attempt a skill test which uses a skill which is undefined, you may choose to define it.

You may choose to give the skill a rating of 4, 5, or 6.

Each of those ratings may only be assigned to a single skill—that is, once you’ve assigned a rating of 6 to a skill, you may not assign a 6 to any other skill.

Once you’ve defined the skill’s rating, roll and resolve the skill test as normal.

This option may be used **three** times, once for each remaining skill.

DEFINING FOCUSES

During play, when you attempt a skill test, and you do not have a focus which applies to that test, you may choose to define one of your remaining focuses.

Once you have chosen the focus, roll and resolve the skill test as normal.

This option may be used **twice**, once for each remaining focus.

DEFINING TALENTS

During play, at any point, you may select a single talent for which you fulfil the requirements and add that talent to those you know. If you are about to attempt a skill test and the talent would provide an advantage on that test, you gain the talent’s benefits on that test.

This option may be used **twice**, once for each remaining talent.

DEFINING DRIVES

During play, when you attempt a skill test, you may choose to define one of your undefined drives.

Decide how important the drive is to your character, and assign the corresponding rating, as shown on the following table:

DRIVE IMPORTANCE	DRIVE RATING	MEANING
1 st	8	This is the single most important thing for you.
2 nd	7	This is a high priority for you.
3 rd	6	This is certainly something that influences you.
4 th	5	You know that this thing matters, but you have other priorities.
5 th	4	You care very little about this thing.

If the drive is your 2nd or 3rd most important (and thus has a rating of 6 or higher), then you must also create a drive statement for it.

When you create a drive statement for your character in this way, you immediately receive a point of Determination.

Once you’ve done this, resolve the skill test as normal; this could include suffering a complication due to the drive statement, though you cannot challenge a drive until the character is complete: that sort of life-changing decision should wait until the character is fully-formed.

This option may be taken **four** times, once for each remaining drive.

DEFINING AMBITION

At any point during play, you may choose to define your character’s ambition. It must be based on the character’s most important drive, and the gamemaster will help you define it to ensure that it will come up in play in future.

This option may be taken **once**.

DEFINING ASSETS

At any point during play, you may choose to define one or your remaining assets. This follows the normal rules for choosing starting assets. You may choose to do this immediately before attempting an action in which the asset would be useful; once you’ve finished defining the asset, continue attempting the action as normal. Remember to be realistic with any asset you might have supposedly been carrying. However, while you can’t have an ornithopter in your pocket, you might come across one ready to fly.

This option may be taken **twice**, once for each remaining asset.

EVERYTHING’S COMPLETE

Once all the options above have been selected, the character is considered complete. From this point on, the character may earn advancement points and spend them to purchase advances.

SUPPORTING CHARACTERS

As described at the start of this chapter, **supporting characters** are the other type of characters created and controlled by the players during a game of *Dune*. Supporting characters are less detailed and are created in a less involved manner than the main player characters, and they are not permanently owned by a single player. Instead, supporting characters are created as and when circumstances require within the game.

Supporting characters serve the following purposes within *Dune*:

- They represent the people who serve the group's House in various minor and lesser capacities, from functionaries, to spies, to soldiers, and more besides. Some of these may even be assets of a player character.
- They allow players to take on different roles in play, allowing them to capitalize on a skillset that doesn't exist among the main characters, to play a more active role in an adventure that doesn't focus on their main character, or to account for players who are absent.
- They allow the players to split their characters between different activities in different locations without being left out of the game for long stretches: players can use supporting characters in situations where their main character isn't present.

USING A SUPPORTING CHARACTER

At the start of a scene, a player may choose which character they are using: their main character, or one of the supporting characters currently available. For the duration of that scene, that player will control the character they have chosen—the character chosen is a player character.

The player, and the gamemaster, should keep in mind—or keep note of—where the main characters and supporting characters are at different times, and it will typically be the case that a player will choose a character located in the scene being established. However, this means that if the gamemaster ends a scene, and then establishes the next scene in a location occupied by a different set of characters, the players can easily switch to the appropriate characters without having to stop and figure out who is involved and who isn't.

If a player has multiple characters in a single scene, then the player may not directly control those other characters. Characters which are not under the direct control of any player cannot perform the full range of actions available to a character under a player's control. Instead, they can do the following things:

- **Difficulty 0 Tests:** A character not directly controlled by a player may attempt any action in which they will automatically succeed, such as any test which has a Difficulty of 0. If required to attempt a test with a Difficulty above 0, an uncontrolled character will automatically fail, without rolling dice.
- **Assistance:** A character not directly controlled by a player may assist another character's tests. The normal rules for assistance apply, and even uncontrolled characters may only assist a single character at a time.
- **Follow Orders:** A character not directly controlled by a player may take actions when ordered. In this instance, the ordering character instructs the uncontrolled character, and then the uncontrolled character can attempt that action—which may include a test—normally, with assistance from the ordering character.
- **Sacrifice:** An uncontrolled character can be sacrificed to prevent a controlled character from being defeated or otherwise incapacitated. This costs 1 point of Momentum or adds 1 to Threat, and causes the uncontrolled character to suffer whatever fate would have befallen the controlled character.

Further, uncontrolled characters can be treated as a trait, to allow a test to be attempted which would otherwise be impossible (for activities that would require multiple people), or to reduce the Difficulty of a test—simply providing an extra pair of hands and an extra set of senses can be valuable. Note that this does mean that, working in concert, a group of uncontrolled characters can achieve more difficult actions—reducing test Difficulty to 0 so that they can attempt and succeed at the action.

If you have multiple characters in a single scene, and the character you are playing is defeated or otherwise incapacitated, you may immediately select a single uncontrolled character to take control of.

CREATING A SUPPORTING CHARACTER

The number of supporting characters present during any game is not fixed, and players do not inherently own any supporting characters: they are shared amongst the entire group and brought into play as-and-when required.

Supporting characters come in two types: minor and notable (these are comparable to those types of non-player character as well). Minor supporting characters are inconsequential subordinates, such as House soldiers or similar servants. Notable supporting characters are specialists, experts, trusted lieutenants, and similar people, though not as important as the main characters.

MINOR SUPPORTING CHARACTERS

You may create an unlimited number of minor supporting characters during play, with each one costing one point of Momentum or adding one to Threat. If you are not controlling another character in the scene, you may ignore this cost for one minor supporting character. This means you always have a free minor supporting character to bring in if you do not have anyone else to play as; bringing in more than that requires spending Momentum or adding to Threat.

You can create a minor supporting character in the following way:

- **Traits:** A minor supporting character has a single trait, which is a basic description of the character's job or role, such as 'House Trooper', 'Servant', or 'Spy'.
- **Drives:** Minor supporting characters do not have any drive scores. Instead, they have a single **Drive** rating, which ranges from 4 to 8, which is added to their target number instead of a drive for any test. This can be thought of as comparable to their Duty drive, as it represents how effective and dutiful they are. They have no drive statements. Most minor supporting characters have a Drive of 5 to begin with. If they serve the secondary domain of the House this may be 6, and if they serve the primary domain it can be 7. Otherwise, especially low ranking minor supporting characters might just start with 4.
- **Skills:** Minor supporting characters have one skill ranked at 6 (which should be the one most relevant to their job), two skills ranked at 5, and two skills ranked at 4.
- **Focuses:** Minor supporting characters have one focus for any skill ranked at 6, two focuses for any skill ranked at 7, and three focuses for any skill ranked at 8 (if an NPC the gamemaster has granted higher score to).
- **Talents:** If your House grants any special benefit to a type of minor supporting character (such as a bonus to House Troopers to reflect special training), this will take the form of a talent. If they do not belong to a House, any talents they have are unique to them.

NOTABLE SUPPORTING CHARACTERS

Per adventure, the group may use up to five notable supporting characters, which are either created new that adventure or were created in prior adventures and are being used again. Your House may increase or decrease this number, as the fortunes of a House can influence the number and caliber of experts and specialists who serve it.

Creating a new notable supporting character costs 3 points of Momentum or adds 3 points to Threat, plus any additional costs incurred during creation. Reusing an existing notable supporting character requires paying half what it cost to create them, rounding up.

To create a Notable supporting character:

- **Traits:** A notable supporting character has one trait, which is a basic description of the character's job or role, such as 'Military Officer', 'Steward', 'Pilot', or 'Scholar'. For an extra +1 to their cost, add a second trait, reflecting the character's reputation.
- **Drives:** Notable supporting characters have scores in two drives, which are rated at 6 and 7. For all other drives, they use a score of 5. They have a single drive statement for one of their higher-rated drives. For an extra +1 to their cost, add a drive statement to their other higher-rated drive.
- **Skills:** Notable supporting characters typically have one skill ranked at 7 (which should be the one most relevant to their job), one ranked at 6, two ranked at 5, and one at 4. For an extra +1 to their cost, add +1 to two different skills.
- **Focuses:** Notable supporting characters have one focus for any skill ranked at 6, two focuses for any skill ranked at 7, and three focuses for any skill ranked at 8. For an extra +1 to their cost, add two additional focuses to any skills rated 6 or higher.
- **Talents:** Notable supporting characters normally have one talent. For an extra +2 to their cost, add a second talent.

CHARACTER ADVANCEMENT



When characters serve their own interests, they have the potential to advance. Actions taken during play which serve a character's personal agenda score advancement points, which in turn allow the character to improve their skills, learn additional focuses, and obtain new talents.

There are a few other ways that characters can gain advancement points as well, but these occur less frequently.

GAINING ADVANCEMENT POINTS

During an adventure, you can gain advancement points in the following ways:

- ❖ **Adversity:** You can gain advancement points from facing difficult situations, making mistakes, and suffering the consequences of actions. Failure is a harsh teacher.
- ❖ **Pain:** Gain 1 advancement point when you are defeated during conflict.
- ❖ **Failure:** Gain 1 advancement point when you fail a test with a Difficulty of 3 or higher.
- ❖ **Peril:** Gain 1 advancement point whenever the gamemaster spends four or more points of Threat at once.

Ambition: You gain advancement points whenever you succeed at an action which supports your ambition (this does not require a skill test, but if the action involved a skill test, the test must have been successful). You receive 1 advancement point if the action made a minor contribution to your ambition, or 3 if the action was a major contribution to your ambition.

Impressing the Group: If the group wants to reward an especially good plan, roleplayed scene, or other especially noteworthy contribution, the player in question may be given an extra advancement point. Such rewards should be restricted to one per session for any player.

USING ADVANCEMENT POINTS

Over time, you will accumulate advancement points. Between adventures, you may choose to use any points you've accumulated to purchase an advance. You may purchase a maximum of a single advance after each adventure.

- ❖ **Skill:** You may increase one of your skills by +1. Each skill may only be advanced in this way once, and no skill may be advanced to more than 8. This costs 10 advancement points, plus 1 for each previous skill advance purchased.
- ❖ **Focus:** You may purchase an additional focus for any skill which is rated 6 or higher. This costs advancement points equal to the number of focuses you already have.
- ❖ **Talent:** You may purchase an additional talent from those available to you. This costs advancement points equal to three times the number of talents you already have.
- ❖ **Asset:** You may select an asset (other than one which only existed for a single scene) to make permanent. This costs 3 advancement points. Alternatively, you may work to improve one of your existing assets, adding +1 to its Quality, by spending advancement points equal to twice the asset's new Quality.

You also have the option to retrain, allowing one ability to atrophy or diminish with disuse while developing another. Retraining in this way halves the number of advancement points required (round up), but comes at a cost:

- ❖ If you retrain a **skill**, then one skill is also reduced by 1, to a minimum of 4. This does not count as the one advancement allowed for that skill.
- ❖ If you retrain a **focus**, then you must remove a single focus you already possess.
- ❖ If you retrain a **talent**, then you must remove a talent you already possess.

A character's drives cannot be altered through advancement. They have their own mechanism for change, described on p.146-147.





CHAPTER 5: RULES

"Science is made up of so many things that appear obvious after they are explained."

—Pardot Kynes